

The Complete Financial Guide for Young Couples

that have strengthened our relationship. Judy and I didn't think so at the time and would gladly have accepted help from our parents, but none was forthcoming; so we stuck it out and made it work.

We were married in the era before easy credit, so we knew we had to get by on what we had. Compared to the problems young couples can get themselves into today, we were blessed to have operated on a pay-as-you-go basis.

I can remember times when we were literally down to our last 25 cents. So we would park our old car and I would hitch rides until we got paid again. Our entertainment would be going to the local zoo and spending our last quarter on peanuts for the monkeys. It might sound difficult now, but back then we were just doing what we had to do. Without a doubt, we are both stronger because of it.

Many times God will allow a financial trial just to test your faith and commitment, one to the other, and to allow you to grow strong together. You don't want somebody bailing you out because eventually you may be faced with even greater trials. You need to tell your parents or friends, "Thanks a lot, but no thanks."

DANGER SIGN: WORKING WIFE

When a wife feels like she *has* to work and there are no alternatives, that's a danger sign.

With the exception of a disabled spouse, it is seldom that a wife has to work. A wife might want to work and her husband might want her to work. As we discussed earlier, that's OK, provided you keep it in balance. But when a wife has to work, then you're living above your means. More money won't help. Her income will be spent and you'll need even more.

I recall an incident that happened to me several years ago. During a counseling session with a couple, I asked the husband, "What's the problem, in your opinion?" His reply was, "We don't make enough money. We only make about \$15,000 a year. There is no way we can live on just \$15,000 a year."

So I got out my budget sheet that lists the various catego-